

Croatia



Formerly part of Hungary and then Yugoslavia, Croatia is now a fully independent state.

168 BCE Romans conquer the kingdom of Illyria, which becomes the Province of Illyricum (later split into Pannonia and Dalmatia).

40 CE Visigoths begin to settle on the coast, with Ostrogoths settling farther inland. The whole country then becomes part of the Ostrogothic kingdom.

640 Croats conquer the Avars. A Croat duchy is formed, the Croats accepting rule by the Franks in the following century. Byzantines settle along the coast.

925 Duke Tomislav takes the title King of Croatia, which is recognized by the papacy. A truce in the conflicts with the Byzantine Empire and its maritime successors, the Venetians, is followed by expansion down the coast in Dalmatia.

1060 Croatia accepts the Roman Catholic rite at the Council of Split, which bans services in Church Slavonic (the language of the Eastern Orthodox church).

1089 The assassination of King Demetrius Zvonimir leads to anarchy. Croatia is conquered by Hungary, Zvonimir's widow being the sister of the Hungarian king. In 1102 Croatia unites with Hungary, although it retains some measure of autonomy.

1526 The Turks defeat the Hungarians at Mohács, and occupy most of Croatia. In 1527 Croatian nobles elect Ferdinand of Austria as their king. Croatia is thus split between the Austro-Hungarian and the Ottoman Empires.

1699 The Ottomans are forced to cede Ottoman-controlled Croatia to Austria-Hungary under the Treaty of Karlowitz, after their failure to capture Vienna in 1683. Recolonization of Croatia with Christians takes place, including establishing pockets of Serbian population in Croatia.

1809 Napoleon captures the Croatian territory held by Austria-Hungary and reorganizes it into an Illyrian province, along French lines, giving an impetus to Croatian national sentiment. Austria-Hungary regains control in 1813.

1843 Hungary imposes a language law making Magyar the official language in Croatia amid increased Croatian nationalism. The Croatian parliament makes Croat the official language in 1847. In 1849 Croatia becomes an Austrian crown land after a revolt in Austrian-controlled Hungary in 1848 is crushed, with the assistance of Croatian (and Russian) troops.

1867 Croatia becomes an autonomous land under Hungarian control once more, as Austria and Hungary divide their Slav



Mayhem at Mohács

Here, Turkish leader Suleyman the Magnificent rides to victory over the Hungarians at the Battle of Mohács in 1526. As a result, the Turks occupied most of Croatia for more than 170 years.

lands after the Habsburgs' defeat by Prussia, and establish the dual monarchy of Austria-Hungary. In 1868 the Hungarians recognize the existence of the Croatian nation, albeit subordinate to Hungary, with its official language, parliament, and ruler, invoking the 12th-century agreement to this effect.

1875 An insurrection against Turkish rule in Herzegovina spreads to Bosnia and provokes a crisis in the region as it spreads to Croatia, where there is agitation for Bosnia to be incorporated into Croatia. This leads to anti-Hungarian rioting in 1883.

1881 Military frontier areas are integrated back into civilian rule.

1912 After nearly a decade of nationalist disturbances and the emergence of a majority Serbo-Croat coalition for Yugoslav unity, which takes power in Croatia in 1906, the Hungarian government suspends the Croatian constitution and imposes a dictatorship.

1914 World War I breaks out, triggered by the murder of the Austrian archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austrian emperor, in Sarajevo, the Bosnian capital. Austria-Hungary clamps down on Croatian nationalism. A group of Croatian exiles in London helps in 1915 to form the Yugoslav Committee and continues to demand union with Serbia.

1918 With Austria-Hungary on the point of collapse at the end of World War I, the Croatian Diet declares independence from Hungary and appeals for help from the Serbian army. In December the Serbian prince, Alexander, proclaims the united kingdom of Serbs, Croats, and Slovenes.

1920 Elections to a Constituent

Assembly result in a centrist government led by the Serb Nikola Pasic. A unitary constitution, promulgated in 1921, is opposed by Croat parliamentarians.

1929 Alexander imposes a dictatorship to end Serbian, Croatian, and Slovene nationalism and renames the country Yugoslavia. However his rule merely increases Serbian domination, bureaucracy, and repression by the police. Alexander is assassinated in 1934.

1941–45 Following the Nazi occupation

of Yugoslavia, Croatia is placed under joint Italian and German control with a puppet government run by the fascist Ustase Party. The Ustase persecute the Serbs and others, killing several hundred thousand of them in Jasenovac and other concentration camps. Serb Chetnik resistance fighters retaliate by killing many Croats in Bosnia and elsewhere.

1945 At the end of the war, Josef Tito, a Croat and the leader of the communist partisans that had largely liberated the country from German control, takes power in Yugoslavia. Up to 200,000 Ustase troops and civilians attempt to flee



Evil of the Ustase

Croatian fascists, the Ustase, summarily execute ethnic Serbs in Croatia during World War II. The Ustase were especially brutal, even by fascist standards, killing thousands and leaving a legacy of anti-Croat feeling, particularly in Serbia.

to safety in Austria, but are caught by Tito's troops; at least 110,000 are killed. Croatia becomes one of the six federal republics within Yugoslavia.

1980 After the death of Tito, Yugoslavia begins to unravel as nationalist tensions, and rivalry between Serbs and Croats, rise to the surface of politics.

1988 The federal Yugoslav government falls when its budget proposals are defeated in the National Assembly. Pressure from Croatia and Slovenia over greater republican autonomy is opposed by hardliners in Serbia, who demand a strong centralized state.

1990 The League of Communists of Yugoslavia votes to abolish its leading role as democratization sweeps across the communist world. However the communist parties of the six republics differ sharply over how to achieve reform.

1990 The nationalist Croatian Democratic Union (HDZ), led by Franjo Tudjman, wins multi-party elections in Croatia. Nationalist parties win elections in Slovenia, Macedonia, and Bosnia-Herzegovina.

1991 Serbia and its allies refuse to support the election of the vice-president of Croatia, Croatian nationalist Stjepan Mesic, as president of the collective state. On June 25 Croatia declares its independence. Serb forces invade Western Slavonia and other regions, while the rebel Serb republic of Krajina, in the west of Croatia, is proclaimed. Bosnian Serbs occupy Eastern Slavonia.

1992 Independence is assured as Serb forces withdraw, but leave a force in Western Slavonia in the center of the country. Franjo Tudjman is president and involves Croatia in the Bosnian war.

1995 Krajina and Western Slavonia are recaptured from Yugoslav forces.

1998 Eastern Slavonia is finally reintegrated into Croatia as agreement is reached with the Bosnian Serbs.

1999 Death of Tudjman; hardline nationalism begins to lose ground.

2000 Center-left Social Democratic Party (SDP) of Stjepan Mesic wins elections and steers Croatia toward Western Europe.

2003 HDZ returns to power, but continues pro-Western policies.

2003 Croatia applies for EU membership.

2007 The ruling HDZ party wins election. An ethnic Serb is appointed to a key position (deputy prime minister) for the first time.

2009 Croatia joins NATO. Talks on joining the EU resume after Slovenia drops its objections.

«110–13 From Republic to Empire

«246–47 The Ottoman Empire

«450–51 War in Yugoslavia